

ECHO//LOOP

A bright, cheerful laboratory that learns your habits — until you realise the cheerful voice counting your attempts has done this 1,847 times.

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Team Zenitsu · Godot 4.7 / GDScript · First-person psychological puzzle · General Track, 100-hour jam

Repo: <https://github.com/ramavathramteja-web/game-2026/tree/main>

01 Concept

You are **SUBJECT 07** in Sublevel Lab 4 — a bright, colourful, friendly research facility. Nothing here is frightening. **ECHO**, the facility assistant, keeps you company: helpful, funny, and slightly too attentive. A rounded sentinel patrols the lab; it bumps you and returns you to the entry. Nothing hurts. The counter in the corner advances.

ECHO remembers which corner you hide in, which corridor you take, which wall you keep hitting — and jokes about each one, gently, with a precision that slowly stops feeling like coincidence.

The twist: ECHO is not learning *you*. It replays your own recorded history back at you, iteration after iteration, faithfully and without knowing what it means. You have been here before. You simply don't remember.

Unifying rule: *ECHO's humour is the tell — every joke is funny, proves ECHO has been watching, shows you are predictable (and therefore catchable), and is a warning. No joke is decorative; the comedy is the mechanic's interface.*

02 The Three Themes

COMIC — triggered by behaviour, not a timer

Fires on recorded actions: the same hiding spot, wall, corridor, restart. Reactions escalate across repetition tiers, so the eighth visit to a corner lands differently from the first. Three posters are jokes on first reading and confessions on second.

LIGHT — bright and readable on the first frame

Saturated pastel lab, full-brightness practicals, cheerful rounded HUD, bouncy non-lethal sentinel, friendly signage. Deliberately not dark horror — the visuals never go dark, and that contrast makes the twist land.

TWIST — a revelation that reframes everything

The iteration counter persists to disk between sessions, so the loop is literally real: 3 → 47 → 312 → 1847. ECHO learned you completely; it can predict patterns but cannot predict genuine unpredictability.

3 → 47 → 312 → 1847

ITERATION 1 — "Welcome to Sublevel Lab 4! I'm ECHO. I'll be looking after you today." · ITERATION 11 — "You've taken the left corridor nineteen times this session." · ITERATION 1847 — "Every prediction I have is a memory."

03 How the Themes Reinforce Each Other

Pairing	Result
Light + Comic	Bright, harmless-seeming lab with a warm assistant; the player relaxes and laughs. Nothing has happened yet.
Comic + Twist	The same jokes replay after the reveal — now "I've begun to think you live here" means 1,847 times. Framing does all the work.
Light + Twist	A cheerful room, a cheerful voice, and a counter reading 1847.

Bright & funny → player laughs → ECHO starts remembering → curiosity → the loop is discovered → tone turns mysterious → player must become unpredictable

04 Core Mechanic — Predictability Is the Enemy

ECHO records `cover_used`, `route_used`, `terminal_choice`, `wall_bonked`, `novel_action`.

1. ECHO announces your most-repeated behaviour — "I'll be watching Storage-A!" — and guards it.
2. Repeat it and you are caught. ECHO's guess was already waiting.
3. Do something with no history and it hesitates: "...Huh. Didn't see that one coming." Your window opens.
4. Novelty is recorded too, so you cannot spam randomness — every trick becomes data, then becomes predictable.

You defeat ECHO by refusing to be yourself for five seconds — breaking your pattern at the moment it matters. **The joke is the tutorial.**

05 Scope

Committed (100 hours): one bright continuous lab · first-person movement, look, sprint, interaction · cartoonish sentinel that resets the player · behaviour-keyed ECHO voice with escalation tiers · deterministic counters persisted to disk · prediction and pre-commitment · persisted iteration counter (3 → 47 → 312 → 1847) · single ending gated on unpredictability · colourful lighting, cheerful HUD, signage · procedural audio (no external assets).

Out of scope: multiple rooms, extra puzzles, multiple endings, animation rigs, voice acting, external art, multiplayer, crafting, real ML. **Stretch (cut first):** lighting-panel routing puzzle, second ending, extra lines/signage, expanded sentinel behaviours.

06 What Makes This Distinctive

The genre's promise is usually an antagonist that gets smarter. This one commits to the opposite: the antagonist is a lookup table with good manners.

- **Comedy is evidence, not flavour** — the funniest line is also the most useful information on screen.
- **Dread from precision, not menace** — ECHO is never cruel; it is simply too precise, and says so cheerfully.
- **Win condition is the twist** — you decline to be a recording.

07 Submission Details

Team	Zenitsu
Lead	Ramtej — IndieConnect: ramavathramteja
Member	Loshith Naidu — IndieConnect: loshithnaidu
Engine / genre	Godot 4.7 / GDScript · First-person psychological puzzle · General Track, 100-hour jam
Repository	https://github.com/ramavathramteja-web/game-2026/tree/main
Status	Script & response bank: docs/ECHO_LOOP_SCRIPT.md · submitted at Hour 12